

Should You Play Genshin Impact?

Genshin Impact is a gacha game with open-world elements and action-based combat released in September 2020. Due to its overwhelming success and ability to be played on virtually any platform, you've probably heard of it! As a free-to-play game, it's earned over ten billion dollars in the last six years, and with that, almost every gamer has an opinion on it. There's a lot to say, as this game uses its resources to be a plethora of things and appeal to the largest net of players. But with that net comes a lot of noise, and a lot of conflicting opinions. So, is Genshin Impact a game for you?

Before you hit download, there's one thing it'd be unfair not to tell you; it is entirely based around the gacha system. In case you're unaware, gacha games are less of a genre and more of a description. You earn or pay for a special in-game currency, and you use it to spin a slot machine and pray for the strongest or prettiest characters and items. In a game like Genshin Impact, you'll receive maybe ten of the hundred or so playable characters without engaging with it. Some players avoid it entirely to challenge themselves on alternate accounts, but it's not something anyone would do for normal enjoyment.

As someone who's experienced this in multiple forms in a plethora of games, I'd say Genshin Impact's system is fairer than most. You get its premium currency, primogems, at a generous rate through normal gameplay, and they set a clear limit on how bad your luck can be before you get the character or item you're hoping for. Someone who plays every day, engaging with all the new content and events as they come out, will likely receive their rare character every two patches, or every three months, without spending real money. Any luck at all, and it becomes much more often.

The game is updated at a constant, unchanging rate, where you can expect a larger update every August with minor expansions every six weeks afterwards. Chronic players still run out of things to do towards the end of those six weeks, but what can you do? If you love a game, you love a game. Now that you know what you're in for from their business model, we can get into the game itself.

You'll load into the game, experience some intro cutscenes with a small tutorial, and immediately be given the option to either start walking around or do the introductory quests. Frankly, the option to jog around this beautiful open world before reading is a rare treat in today's RPG scene! Obviously, there's only so much you can do before the story is required, but it's a good taste of the freedom you'll later be given. A few hours of gameplay later, you'll have opened enough chests and spoken to enough people to have complete freedom of movement within their map.

The scenery everywhere is undeniably beautiful. The color scheme choices are tastefully saturated, matching the game's anime style, and each region has a distinct cultural feel. A strong effort to stay true to the inspiring nations' backgrounds, from their names to the items and enemies within, as well as the history they blend into their lore,

was a constant guiding force in the creation of the world. However, as this game is based in China, the designers unfortunately do stick to Chinese beauty standards in the creation of most characters. Though they nailed everything else, ninety-nine percent of characters are very pale, and even the less pale are nowhere near dark-skinned.

These characters, which you gamble for using their premium currency, as previously described, are as beautiful as the world they're placed in. Each one is distinct, with detailed backstories and personalities, making it easy to fall in love with them over and over again. That's how gacha games get you: every character is so gorgeous you'll want 'em all!

There's very little freedom in how they're used or how they look, though. Only a few characters have separate outfits you could buy, and this isn't a game where changes can be made to them. Their skillsets are also locked in, making each serve a very specific combat role. Their strength and expected usefulness are what push a lot of players to spend on some over others, just as much as their appearance.

The combat is fairly straightforward, easily approachable to a casual gamer. You can use four of your characters at a time, combining their elements and combat abilities to set up elemental reactions for extreme damage. Most fights will require a certain element or weapon type, largely dependent on what region you're exploring or, for endgame content, what patch you're in.

It takes a while to learn everything, but it doesn't take much time to understand what's important. The game includes a fleshed-out guide that adds to itself as you experience things within the menus, so as long as you're okay with reading two sentences every once in a while, there's no room to be confused. And if you aren't open to reading two sentences, how'd you get this far into this article?

To make characters stronger, you spend something called "resin". It's essentially an energy system, similar to Facebook games, which would ask you to invite your friends to be able to play more. To dodge the tediousness of this, you're at first given plenty of resources to refill this energy, but it eventually slows your progress quite a bit. I understand complaints, but personally, I also understand the need to turn off a faucet to ensure there's water tomorrow. Genshin Impact doesn't want you to play all day for a week and get bored; it wants you to play for an hour or so daily. The design choice, in most respects, makes the game more enjoyable.

You use this energy to rank up characters' levels, skills, gear, and weapons. Currently, you get about ten uses of it per day, which feels fine once you're towards the more idle higher levels. Of course, there are other ways to do all of those things, like exploring or clearing endgame content, but the bulk of it is from this energy system.

World exploration is what hooks most players, and the style brought a lot of comparisons to The Legend of Zelda: Breath of the Wild when Genshin Impact was first released. Each region brings its own style of small fights, puzzles, and short quests, which reward the player with the premium currency required to make wishes.

Eventually, you do run out of things to explore, but it's a blast turning over every rock and leaf. As an endgame player, with every map completed to its entirety, I'd estimate each region holds about eight to twelve hours of exploration to enjoy without needing to talk to an NPC at all. If open-world exploration draws you in, and you're into it being a single-player experience, you'll struggle to find a game that delivers it in a stronger, more addicting form. You'll have to consider setting a timer to watch how long you've spent and pull yourself away.

The story behind the game is incredibly large and colorful. It's been known that the writers intend for it to be converted to an anime one day, and the number of years we'll have meaningful episodes for is honestly overwhelming. Each region has a few-hour-long quests based around the main character, mixed with smaller quests to add depth to the world and individual chapters for each of the rare characters.

It's reasonable to assume most more jaded, stoic, adult players would eventually find it somewhat grating, though. The writing leans a lot into a cutesy, anime style which could be approached by a preteen and teenage demographic, and if that's not your thing, it probably won't grow on you here. Though at times, I get annoyed and bored reading it, and let it idly run in the background of other games I play just to get through it, their larger moments are emotionally strong, and their animated cutscenes are visually stunning.

Something to note is that though there are multiplayer elements, this is largely a single-player game. If you don't enjoy it by yourself, don't bother reaching the level to play it with others, as you'll only be able to do the same things in a slightly more restrictive manner. A cute addition on top of this already enormous game, which is more multiplayer-based than the rest, is called "Miliastra Wonderland". At a certain, not too high level, you'll unlock the ability to teleport to this mode, creating a custom character to play minigames. The best way to explain it is, well, have you played Roblox? It's Roblox. We've got Roblox in Genshin Impact.

The community does a good job constantly adding games, and the developers have made a habit of paying players for the creation of new mechanics they intend to use in future content or that they want to highlight for newer players. A bunch of kids are getting an introductory course on game design this way, and that's undeniably pleasant, even if the results are often goofy. Of course, most of how you'd customize this character you make is trapped behind yet another gacha system, but you'll get some stuff over time. Not as generous as the base game, but not horrendous.

If you're looking for a quiet, mostly single-player open-world RPG, and are accepting of a somewhat cutesy story backing up a beautifully addictive world, Genshin Impact is free and absolutely worth a try. If it isn't your cup of tea, though, it isn't a game that'll change your mind on the genre.